

Modern humans

Fossil evidence and studies of our genes show that our own species—*Homo sapiens*—evolved in Africa some 200,000 years ago. Around 60,000 years ago, modern humans spread from Africa to new continents, taking with them tools, art, and a way of life more advanced than anything seen before. As our species spread, other more primitive humans and many large mammal species vanished—perhaps victims of our success.



▲ BURIAL ORNAMENTS
This 24,000-year-old skeleton of a young man was found in a cave in Italy, adorned with a hat and a necklace made of shells.

Homo sapiens

HOE-moe SAP-ee-enz

- **When** 200,000 years ago to now (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide, except for Antarctica and some remote islands
- **Habitat** Nearly all land habitats
- **Height** 6 ft (1.8 m)

Compared to other apes and primitive humans, *Homo sapiens* has a small, flat face; a high forehead; a huge, balloon-shaped braincase; small brow ridges; and a prominent chin. Most importantly, our species has a large and complex brain. Intelligence allowed our ancestors to devise ingenious new hunting tools, build shelters, make clothes, and harness fire. Language allowed them to pool knowledge and share skills. Early *Homo sapiens* lived in complex societies in which people looked after their sick and left offerings in graves—a sign they believed in an afterlife.

